

PHIL 301

Seminar Paper WORKING DRAFTS, Due by Friday 12/1 11:59 pm

Instructions:

The syllabus says this:

The entire course is designed to enable you to write a polished, longer (2500-2800 words), argumentative seminar paper in which you defend your own view on the issue of freedom of speech and hate speech. Drafts of these papers will be due via BB on Friday December 1. You will discuss your draft with me during a paper conference, on Tuesday December 5, or Thursday December 7.

The working drafts you submit must consist of two parts: *Part 1* will be a thesis+outline, similar to the thesis+outline I posted on BB; *Part 2* will be a working draft of the paper in support of the thesis that follows the structure of the outline. I do not expect your working drafts to be polished, but they should give the reader a good idea of the thesis, and your argument in support of it. (I will expect the final drafts to be polished!)

I encourage you to deploy techniques and devices we have discussed:

1. Begin with an introductory section in which you state your thesis. The introduction should provide background information about the topic only to the extent that such information is required for understanding your thesis.
2. After you state your thesis, provide a “roadmap” which explains to the reader *how* you are going to argue in support of your thesis.
3. Divide your paper into appropriately titled subsections; this will communicate the structure of your paper to your reader. You should refer to the relevant sections in the “road map.”
4. When possible, incorporate citations from the authors you discussing into your own sentences.
5. To explicate complex arguments and claims, use block quotes.
6. Use footnotes or endnotes to provide the reader with relevant background information that is not directly relevant to the line of thought developed in the body of the paper.
7. For each paragraph you write, ask, “What is the main point of this paragraph? How does that point related to my thesis? Have I made the answers to the questions sufficiently obvious to the reader?”
8. For each sentence you write, ask, “Is this a correctly punctuated *sentence*? Is it *true*? Is the sentence precise and clear? Can it be simplified? Why is this sentence *here*, as opposed to somewhere else, i.e. how does the sentence serve to support the main point of the paragraph in which it occurs?”
9. Do all of your *definite noun phrases* have a *clear antecedent*? (E.g. if you write ‘this objection’, is it clear *which* objection you are referring to?)
10. Ask questions to focus your reader’s attention, e.g., “What reasons does Scanlon provide in support of Mill’s Principle?” After posing a question, proceed to answer it.

